What if the most familiar thing in our lives is also one of the biggest mysteries in the universe?

We wake up, watch clocks move, grow older, and watch planets orbit stars. We call the sequence of these changes “time.” But are we actually observing time itself? Or are we observing change and giving the relationship between events the name time?

Think about a universe in which absolutely nothing changes. No movement. No thoughts. No heartbeat. No atoms changing state. No clock ticking. If there were truly no change at all, what could a clock measure? There would be no event before another event and no event after it. There would be nothing to compare.

This does not prove that time does not exist. Instead, it creates a deeper possibility: perhaps time is not a fundamental substance flowing through the universe. Perhaps what we experience and measure as time emerges from changes and relationships between events.

This idea matters because the future may give humanity tools that we cannot imagine today. By 2050, science could have answered questions that seem impossible now. What if future physics discovered a way to travel backward through time?

I am not claiming that such a device can be built today. I am asking what the consequences might be if backward time travel became physically possible.

That leads to one of the most famous problems in time travel: the grandfather paradox. Imagine a traveller goes into the past and changes an event that prevents their own grandfather from having children. Then the traveller would never be born. But if the traveller was never born, who went back in time and caused the change?

My proposed possibility is that the traveller does not rewrite their original universe. Instead, suppose parallel universes already exist. A future time-travel device might, in this hypothesis, send the traveller into the past of another universe.

The traveller could change events there, but those changes would belong to that parallel universe. The universe the traveller originally came from would keep its own history.

I am not saying the traveller creates a new universe. I am proposing that the traveller enters an already-existing parallel universe. The “glitch” is only a simple way of imagining the transition. The real physical mechanism would be unknown.

This idea has serious weaknesses. Some scientific theories allow the possibility of a multiverse, but the existence of parallel universes has not been experimentally confirmed. Even if parallel universes exist, we have no demonstrated method for travelling between them.

We also cannot currently prove that a traveller could change another universe without affecting the original one. If the traveller could not observe both universes and compare them, testing the idea could be extremely difficult.

My argument about time does not prove that time is unreal. The fact that we need change to measure time does not automatically mean time does not exist. It only shows that our measurements depend on physical processes and relationships between events.

Therefore, I would describe my idea as a philosophical possibility: time might be emergent rather than fundamental, while the measurable effects associated with time remain real.

What if the clocks we build do not directly reveal a mysterious substance called time, but instead measure patterns of change? What if our understanding of time changes when our understanding of the universe changes?

And if backward time travel ever becomes possible, could entering an already-existing parallel universe provide a way around the grandfather paradox without rewriting the traveller's original history?

Maybe the greatest mystery of time is not how fast it moves, or whether we can travel through it. Maybe the greatest mystery is whether time is a fundamental part of reality at all.

In 2050, future scientists may have better experiments, better mathematics, and better technology. They may prove my idea wrong, improve it, or discover something completely different.

But every discovery begins with a question. Mine is simple: What if time isn't real in the way we think it is?